

CORRECT ACT Voters with their documents at Nazat, North 24 Parganas, W. Bengal

handled 50-odd a month. Now, 100-150 people are trooping in daily to correct the smallest of spelling errors," says an officer in South 24 Parganas. The rush, he adds, is especially visible in Muslim-majority areas.

Rasida Bibi and Aaijoddi Khan, a middle-aged couple from Sarberia village in the district, exemplify this. They have been voting for decades without difficulty. Yet, they recently joined the crowds at their local office to correct spellings on their documents. "Don't you know?" Rasida asks earnestly. "From now, voter cards won't have names in Bengali. All names will be in English. Isn't it necessary that the spellings are right?" Rumour, rather than any official word, fuels the fear.

Takeaways

- **EC yet to notify SIR in Bengal, but panic has spread on the ground**
- **Border districts see a surge in applications to clean up ID documents**
- **Officials say the rush is especially visible in Muslim-majority areas**
- **Amidst rush for digital papers, BJP alleges local bodies enabling fakes**
- **TMC says EC's acts are "politically motivated"**

DIGITAL DUST-CLOUDS

But it's set off a huge demand for digitised certificates. Old birth papers, often fabricated post facto, were riddled with errors—digital cleaning at panchayat offices is seen to offer a new layer of authentication. For domicile, too, says a BDO in South Dinajpur, "Applications have shot up since July, with the Bihar SIR."

Officers, too, have begun tightening the rules. Any supporting document signed by, say, a pradhan must now be countersigned by the panchayat executive officer, a government employee. Those above 21 seeking their first voter ID must submit Annexure III, a self-declaration explaining why they did not apply upon turning 18. "Migrant labourers often leave home at an early age and miss the 18-year window. We are allowing up to 21, not beyond," says an officer.

Physical verification is another issue. "Faces can change drastically from old ID photos. Also, Muslim women used to be reluctant to lift their burqas. Now, they are more cooperative," says another.

The politicking is getting fierce. The BJP claims offline birth certificates are being issued at will, alleging rampant fabrication. The TMC, in turn, calls the EC's September 20 deadline for cross-matching the 2002 electoral rolls with the present list "arbitrary and politically motivated".

On the ground, an ancillary industry has sprung up. Photocopy shops and cyber cafes are selling printed extracts of the 2002 rolls—available free on the state election office's website. Touts and middlemen lurk outside offices, promising faster service for up to Rs 2,000. Identity is both personal and political—but it's also business. ■

▶ GUJARAT

CUTTING REAMS OF RED TAPE

Government offices in the state see a spring breeze of new ideas as self-reform kicks in

By **Jumana Shah**

"YOU CAN'T MOVE MOUNTAINS BY WHISPERING AT THEM," says a senior bureaucrat in Gujarat, glancing at four bulky volumes on his desk—all reports submitted by the Gujarat Administrative Reforms Commission (GARC) in the first six months of its two-year tenure. Headed by retired IAS officer Hasmukh Adhia, who serves as advisor to chief minister Bhupendra Patel, the commission has the unenviable mandate of taking a hard look at the functioning of the entire state government and its various arms. Judging by its first four reports, it isn't short of enthusiasm.

The panel has already recommended sweeping measures, of which 25 are under various stages of implementation. Mundane, yet monumental tasks. And potentially mind-shifting for a babucracy wedded to old, lethargic ways. These range from upgrading the SOPs for disposal of old furniture and cars, to having a QR code on government documents that would allow citizens to access their data online or in their digilocker.

"The broader vision is to bring a massive change in the style of governance," says the bureaucrat, cautiously. "This is a complex system where lakhs work. Change will take longer than in a private entity. We have started with small, effective reforms."

The first report, submitted in March, was inspired by the Kaizen philosophy of continuous improvement. Its focus was on changes to improve productivity and employee working conditions in Sachivalay, the state secretariat in Gandhinagar. To this end, it suggested